al-Qaeda was establishing some of its training bases.[151] In the early years after 9/11, while al-Qaeda and the Taliban were re-establishing their training capacity, Lashkar picked up some of the slack. This included training local militants as well as foreigners who pre-9/11 would have trained in al-Qaeda camps, but now were looking for other avenues of instruction. For example, a stream of militants from Indonesian militant groups began passing through Lashkar's induction program after 9/11. Some of them belonged to Jemaah Islamiyah [Islamic Group or JI], which was responsible for the 2002 Bali bombings, and others to Lashkar Jihad, a group dedicated to fighting Christians in Indonesia.[152] In September 2003, Indonesian and Malaysian students linked to JI were arrested in Karachi from the JuD-affiliated madrasa Jamaat-ul-Dirasat-ul-Islamiyah.[153] Among those arrested was a student alleged to be the brother of Nurjaman Riduan Ismuddin [a.k.a. Hambali], the mastermind behind the 2002 Bali bombings.[154] In addition to trainees looking for new venues of instruction, the closing of al-Qaeda's camps also meant that its freelance trainers needed to find new places to set up shop, and some of them gravitated to Lashkar. This cut both ways and as al-Qaeda re-established its infrastructure in Pakistan, some Lashkar trainers began working at its camps as well.[155]

Lashkar was an appealing outfit for would-be Western jihadis because it maintained a more robust training apparatus and received less scrutiny than other groups. Some Westerners who sought training in Pakistan after 9/11 were looking to fight in Afghanistan or Indian-administered Kashmir, though the latter was a less attractive option and sometimes viewed merely as a means of gaining combat experience. Others were looking for training in urban terrorism, which they intended to employ to prosecute attacks back in Europe or North America. Notably, there were instances in which Westerners sought training in order to fight on open fronts, but were reoriented toward participating in terrorist plots abroad or providing logistical support to established outfits. Lacking in combat experience and familiarity with the local language or terrain, often their most useful assets were a passport from a Western country and perhaps a 'clean skin,' meaning they did not feature on terrorist watch lists.

Although the Musharraf regime directed Lashkar not to host foreigners in its camps, attempts at enforcing this directive were lax and easily evaded.